

Understanding Benzodiazepines

General guidance on benzodiazepine medications used short-term for anxiety, panic or insomnia, and their dependence risk.

What are benzodiazepines used for?

Benzodiazepines (such as clonazepam, alprazolam or lorazepam) provide fast-acting relief for acute anxiety, panic attacks, or short-term insomnia. Because of dependence risk, they are generally prescribed for short-term or occasional use rather than as a long-term daily treatment.

What to expect

- Effects are usually felt within 30-60 minutes
- Typically prescribed for the shortest effective duration, or used on an as-needed basis
- Often used as a short bridge while a longer-term treatment (such as an SSRI or CBT) takes effect

Common side effects

- Drowsiness or sedation
- Impaired coordination or reaction time — avoid driving or operating machinery if affected
- Memory difficulties, particularly with higher doses

Important safety notes

- Regular use for more than a few weeks can lead to physical dependence, and stopping abruptly can cause withdrawal, including seizures in severe cases
- Never combine with alcohol or opioid medications, since this significantly increases the risk of dangerous breathing suppression

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- Any dose reduction or discontinuation after regular use should be gradual and supervised by your psychiatrist
- Use particular caution in older adults, given increased fall and confusion risk

When to seek urgent help

Seek emergency medical care for severe drowsiness, confusion or breathing difficulty (especially if combined with alcohol or other sedatives), or for seizures during dose reduction.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

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